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Rose

Late November 1942

On the train, the knots in Rose's stomach tightened. Fiddling with the edge of her leather satchel, she wondered how long Léa would remain angry. In the crowded passenger carriage, men and women squeezed onto the seats, and the windows steamed up, so there was nothing to see outside. They sat next to one another, and every time Rose tried to start a conversation, Léa ignored her.

"What do you think Paris will be like?" Rose asked, trying again when she could no longer bear the silence.

Léa closed her eyes.

The morning after Léa's arrest, Rose had sought the help of Maître Mallon. She'd gone to the address written in Léa's notebook—on the top floor of an old building in the center of Orléans. Trudging up the rickety stairs, Rose recalled the *boiserie* paneling on the walls of his former office, where Léa had worked all those years, the tall windows that let in buckets of light. This building was nothing like that. The paint was peeling off the walls, the landing on the stairs wobbled, and no concierge checked visitors. Rose, panting by the time she reached the fifth floor, could hardly believe the state of the apartment inside—a single room with a sink in a corner and boxes stacked in every space. She wasn't sure where to sit because there were only boxes. He explained to her that the boxes held all his files and books.

"You must be here on account of Léa." He motioned to a box. "Has something happened?" His brow furrowed. "She was the best typist. Fast. Efficient. Diligent."